Adventure Ardeche

Staff Handbook

Matt Thompson, Adventure Ardeche

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1. Staff Handbook

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> **Info**
>
> A way to evangelize, explain, and support solutions to peers so they can be correctly used and successfully adopted

Supporting **Learning Objectives** & **Efficiency** to create **High Quality Provision** & making learning outdoors accessible to all.

1.0.1 EMPOWER YOUNG PEOPLE TO THRIVE

Immersion in the outdoors builds core skills for their future.

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2. Overview

This online document is essentially a **HANDBOOK** to guide you through the systems in place at **Adventure Ardeche**.

> **Tip**
>
> Those systems are laid out in the menu on the left in order of need.

The handbook is provided so that staff have a easily accessible reference to the informations, systems, other resources etc to hand. It is also available as a paper based resource in the Centre Managers office and Activity Managers office. You can also load as a **.pdf** by clicking the icon in the top right of the browser window.

The handbook is designed so that whenever a staff member is unsure of their requirements they can firstly refer to the handbook, before then approaching either the Activity Manager or Centre Manager for further clarification of their query.

The information contained here is under a continual process of updating and development. **Critical Information** ie. *Risk Assessments* or *Policies & Procedures* are reviewed yearly or after an incident.

> **Warning**
>
> Critical Information should not change, and if it does, staff will be informed through the **staff meeting** channel.

Your contribution is essential to expanding, simplifing, and editing the information contained here. Please feel free to suggest any changes, amendments, or additions to either the Activity Manager or Centre Manager or one of the **Leadership Team**.

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3. Expectations

3.1 Staff Expectations

The ability to introduce, present, instruct and enthuse about the subject or activity you are employed for.

An up-to-date knowledge of all safety and technical aspects of the subject or activity for which you are employed.

The ability to effectively manage the activity for which you are employed, and to deal effectively with all worst-case scenarios that you might encounter during the activity, hence all instructors must make available use of all appropriate safety equipment and familiarise themselves with respective emergency procedures.

The ability to enable, motivate and support each and every individual customer: We do not expect staff to run "**standard**" activities, i.e. if one individual needs greater attention than another, we expect that it be provided with skill and without prejudice in order that that individual gains as much as they desire, rather than being required to conform to "normal" requirements.

> **Note**
>
> We expect that staff will go out of their way for our customers! A polite, courteous and supportive approach to all customers, members of the public and fellow staff members.

- That the Leadership Team is informed about any personal issue that may affect the quality of any aspect of your operation:
- Such information should be given openly, and at the earliest possible opportunity.
- We expect that staff will go out of their way to ensure that this happens.
- An up-to-date knowledge and awareness of legal responsibilities, Health and Safety issues, PPE regulations, and risk assessment requirements.
- That all accidents, incidents and near misses are reported.
- That all first aid treatments are reported.
- That any information about guests that might be required prior to medical treatment, is obtained, recorded, and passed on to others only on a need to know basis, in confidence, and at the earliest opportunity.
- That any questions regarding Health and Safety, guest care, professional duty, and any other matter between guest(s), and Adventure Ardeche personnel are referred to the Leadership Team at the earliest opportunity.

3.1.1 Code of Practice

For the safety and wellbeing of those involved in any activities during an Adventure Ardeche activity.

> **Info**
>
> The purpose of this code is to state the practice that should be in use during any activity in relation to organisational, safety, and the physical well-being of everyone concerned.

3.1.2 This code will be successfully operational when:

- A good working relationship and clear communication exists between the staff running the activity and their guests and the Leadership Team.
- We (*all staff involved*) carefully plan and prepare all activities and identify special and particular needs as early as practicable

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- We clearly define objectives for the activity, relating to the age group and type of our guests, and clearly identify the overall aims of each guest and guest group
- Each instructor, or facilitator is competent to deliver the activity for which they have been employed
- Our resources and facilities are well managed.
- Adventure Ardeche staff must always be prepared to adapt, and to be flexible in their outlook, and in their management of resources to ensure that we create a safe and enjoyable experience for all the guests who have placed their trust in our organisation.
- The information contained in this document is intended to be guidance for all people working within Adventure Ardeche. It is expected that all people working within Adventure Ardeche read, digest and use this information, and where they recognise that improvements could be made, they take it upon themselves to inform the Leadership Team.
- We support the development of and interaction between staff and the Leadership Team with the intention of improving the odds against unsafe operation in hazardous situations.
- We foresee that any staff member may opt to take actions that fall outside the scope of this document in order to maintain a safe environment, and where there is sufficient evidence to suggest that their course of action is justified, we will support them.
- Each staff member will make judgements according to their own training and experiences, and we support those decisions that are taken in order to create a safe working environment and to reduce the risk to health in any given situation.
- Adventure Ardeche policies and procedures are published for guidance and we recognise that qualified and experienced staff will use their expertise to design appropriate solutions for different situations, locations and guest types.
- The nature of our business is such that the aims and objectives of our guests may be to increase the risks that they take. Our policy is to ensure that these risks are reduced to a reasonable level and that the guest is fully aware of the hazards and the consequences.
- We will always support a guest in achieving their objectives as safely as possible, and will advise and instruct a guest in support of his or her objectives. Where a guests' objectives and intentions are not conducive to a safe and positive outcome we will advise against their actions and prevent them from proceeding where appropriate.
- We expect that the standard and practises specified by the National Governing Bodies are, on the whole, adopted as a basic minimum standard for the relevant activities, and where no specification has been made, that the staff involved discuss their intended safe operating practises with the Leadership Team or persons notified by them (*Technical Advisors*).

3.1.3 How to look after clients

What we expect, what the guest can expect, what legal responsibilities we have and what should not be done!

Note

Adventure Ardeche is not intended to be an organisation that offers poor or even average standards of service. We expect that all staff working within Adventure Ardeche perform to an excellent standard, which is clearly obvious to all.

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The following criteria are laid down as the result of feedback from past guests who have found our service to be excellent.

Our guests can expect the following from all personnel:

- High standards of personal presentation.
- Exceptional punctuality.
- Attention to detail.
- A focus on the guest experience at all times.
- Polite, courteous and proactively helpful behaviour.
- Open, honest communication.
- High standards of technical skill.
- Clear and appropriate instruction.
- Safe practice.
- An enabling, inspiring and enjoyable experience.

3.1.4 Standard Staff Practices

We expect that a staff member carries out the following regardless of the activity they are undertaking. These guidelines are offered as a check for all staff– we recognise that different methods may be used to achieve these results.

- Get one or more appropriate weather forecasts.
- Gather up to date information about your guests (medical, fitness, behavioural and dietary) from the Leadership Team or directly from the participants.
- Ensure that your Leadership Team knows your intended route or activity site, ETA and party details.
- Ensure that you have any activity appropriate kit with you.
- Identify yourself to the group, introduce yourself by name, and ensure that all accompanying adults are aware of your role.
- Clearly identify the role you want any accompanying adults to take, even if it is a passive role.
- Ensure that each client is appropriately dressed and equipped for the activity.
- Carry, and know how to use appropriate 1st Aid, safety and rescue equipment.
- Provide a clear overview and briefing for all activities and re-brief whenever the activity changes.
- Learn the first names of all of your guests.
- Watch for individuals struggling and provide additional help and encouragement.
- Provide clear warnings in advance of any significant hazard followed by appropriate instruction and equipment as required.
- Record any incidents or accidents in the appropriate place and notify the Leadership Team

3.1.5 Standard Instructor Kit

All instructors must ensure the following is available at any time during an activity:

- First aid kit
- Group shelter or large survival bag
- Reliable light source if operating in the evenings
- Any safety or rescue equipment appropriate to the prevailing and anticipated conditions, the nature of the activity and the number, type and ability of guests. This might normally include spare clothing, food/energy source, hydration and an appropriate form of communication.

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3.1.6 Basic Philosophies

Whilst engaging in an activity for the pure element of participation and fun is valuable, many of our guests are at a period of their development where sound role-modelling and example is of great benefit to them. As an Instructor at Adventure Ardeche you are in an enviable position where the example you set is a foundational block in a guests life journey, use that position/opportunity with clear thought.

Learning Through Experience

- Engaging Experiences
- Promote Skill Mastery
- Incorporate Reflection
- Learn from both Success & Failure

Challenge & Adventure

- Through Unfamiliar Settings
- Through activities that are Mentally & Physically Challenging
- Guests have ‘More in them than they know’

Supportive Environment

- Provide both Physical and Emotional Safety
- Be a Skilled & Compassionate Instructor
- Foster a Caring, Positive, and Inclusive culture

3.1.7 As a member of Adventure Ardeche staff, live positively…

Physical Fitness

Build physical and emotional stamina to meet challenges.

Craftsmanship

Model quality and intention through your actions.

Self-Reliance

Be resourceful, apply personal strengths.

Compassion

Engage in the welfare and dignity of others.

What people have the capacity to choose, they have the abilities to change.
Madeleine K Albright

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4. Risk Assessments

4.1 Ardeche Descent RA

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4.2 Raft Build RA

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4.3 Stand Up Paddling RA

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4.4 Gorge Trek RA

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4.5 Foss Hill RA

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4.6 Initiatives RA

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4.7 Adventure Challenge RA

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4.8 Ardeche Olympics RA

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5. Policies

5.1 Child Protection & Safeguarding

Effective safeguarding systems are child centred. Failings in safeguarding systems are too often the result of losing sight of the needs and views of the children within them, or placing the interests of adults ahead of the needs of children. Children want to be respected, their views to be heard, to have stable relationships with professionals built on trust and for consistent support provided for their individual needs. This should guide the behaviour of professionals.

Anyone working with children should see and speak to the child; listen to what they say; take their views seriously; and work with them collaboratively when deciding how to support their needs.

5.1.1 Children have said that they need:

- **Vigilance:** to have adults notice when things are troubling them;
- **Understanding and action:** to understand what is happening; to be heard and understood; and to have that understanding acted upon;
- **Stability:** to be able to develop an on-going stable relationship of trust with those helping them;
- **Respect:** to be treated with the expectation that they are competent rather than not; Information and engagement: to be informed about and involved in procedures, decisions, concerns and plans;
- **Explanation:** to be informed of the outcome of assessments and decisions and reasons when their views have not met with a positive response;
- **Support:** to be provided with support in their own right as well as a member of their family;
- **Advocacy:** to be provided with advocacy to assist them in putting forward their views.

Effective ongoing action to keep the child in focus also includes:

- Eliciting the child's wishes and feelings - about their situation now as well as plans and hopes for the future;
- Providing children with honest and accurate information about the current situation, as seen by professionals, and future possible actions and interventions;
- Involving the child in key decision-making;
- Providing appropriate information to the child about his or her right to protection and assistance;
- Inviting children to make recommendations about the services and assistance they need and/or are available to them;
- Ensuring children have access to independent advice and support, to be able to express their views, and influence decision-making.

Even initial discussions with children should be conducted in a way that minimises any distress caused to them and maximises the likelihood that they will provide helpful information. Children may need time and more than one opportunity in order to develop sufficient trust to communicate any concerns they may have, especially if they have a communication impairment, learning disabilities, are very young or are experiencing mental health problems.

5.1.2 Policy

- Having zero-tolerance for child abuse.
- Protecting children’s rights and their best interests.
- Placing the child as the first priority when dealing with all identified or suspected cases of child abuse.
- Empowering and educating children on their rights, personal safety and steps they can take, if there is a problem.

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5.1.3 Preventing Abuse

- Physical abuse, Neglect, Emotional abuse, and Sexual abuse
- Training children, staff and volunteers on how to identify and prevent child abuse.
- Giving children the opportunity to participate in programmes that educate them on their rights, personal-safety techniques and steps they can take in case of a problem.
- Encouraging and supporting children, staff and community members to report cases of abuse.
- Allowing all children and teens the opportunity to participate in programmes regardless of gender, sexual orientation, disability, ethnicity or religion
- Integrating child protection into all aspects of our organisational strategy, structures and work practices.

5.1.4 Protocols

- Nominated Person for Child Protection/Safeguarding
- Adhere to Best Practice wherever possible

Best Practice means

- Always working in an open environment (e.g. avoiding private or unobserved situations and encouraging open communication with no secrets).
- Treating all young people/disabled adults with respect and dignity.
- Always putting the welfare of each young person first, before achieving goals or winning.
- Maintaining a safe and appropriate distance (e.g. it is not appropriate for staff or volunteers to have an intimate relationship with a child or to share a room with them).
- Building relationships based on mutual trust, which empowers children to share in the decision-making process.
- Making activities fun, enjoyable and promoting fair play, without prejudice.
- Ensuring that if any form of manual/physical support is required, it should be provided openly and appropriately. Care is needed, as it is difficult to position hands appropriately in certain circumstances. Young people should ideally be consulted and their agreement gained where possible. Some parents are becoming increasingly sensitive about manual support and their views should always be carefully considered.
- Involving parents/carers/teachers whenever appropriate. For example, engaging them to take responsibility for their children in the changing rooms. If groups have to be supervised in the changing rooms, try to ensure that parents, teachers, instructors or volunteers work in pairs.
- Ensuring that where possible, a male and female member of staff should always accompany mixed groups. However, remember that same-gender abuse can also occur.
- Ensuring that during residential events, adults should avoid entering children's bedrooms and should never invite children into their private rooms.
- Being an excellent role model – this includes not smoking or drinking alcohol in the company of young people. Giving enthusiastic and constructive feedback rather than negative criticism.
- Recognising the developmental needs and capacity of young people with and without disabilities – avoiding excessive physical activity or competition and not pushing them against their will.
- Create and Maintain an Anti-Bullying environment
- Recruit staff safely. Ensure **ALL** relevant checks are made.
- Effective management through Supervision, Support, Training, Monitoring, Quality Assurance.
- Provision of a **Safe Environment** at all times, by applying best practice **Health & Safety** guidance and other legal requirements.
- Manage any allegations appropriately and in a timely manner.

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> **Note**
>
> Staff/volunteers are not trained to deal with situations of abuse or to decide if abuse has occurred.

This document is in place to ensure safeguarding is at the heart of what we do. All staff take part in safeguarding training during their induction.

5.1.5 Resources

United Kingdom

Save The Children - Child Protection Policy PDF

NSPCC Helpline: 0808 800 5000

France

Nominated child protection and safeguarding officer

Name: Ian McInnes

Phone/email: 0033612502021 / ian@adventureardeche.com

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5.2 Risk Mitigation

5.2.1 A Simple Risk Assessment Process

Managing safety through compliance has traditionally been at the forefront of thinking when it comes to safety. However, organisations might approach safety in 2 ways: by paying greater attention to the traditional tools of risk assessments and risk controls, often built upon risk avoidance, risk prevention or repression; or by learning to deploy a broader and more informed perspective of safety, beyond the applying and monitoring of controls, to that of **safety by design**.

A Modern Approach

Understanding safety by design starts instead by investing in **shared values and beliefs**, interacting with our organisation's structures and control systems to produce behavioural norms. That is, how the people and the cultures they develop, support a healthy **safety climate**.

In organised outdoor learning it is common for there to be a residual level of risk that is judged to be tolerable and in balance with the benefits that will accrue.

It is desirable to give equal consideration to risks and benefits throughout the planning process to avoid benefits being eclipsed by a small possibility of harm.

Hazards and risks cannot be considered in isolation; it is necessary to consider the maturity and experience of learners, the expertise of those leading them, wishes of parents and many other factors. En gagement with actual risk is vital if learners are to develop the skills to deal with the succession of risks they will meet in their own lives.

Look, explore, listen, etc - get to know the environment that you are working in, and the potential interaction between you, your participants and that environment. There is no point in assessing a risk without knowledge of the full implications.

Info

We believe young people take strides in their development when negotiating a controlled level of risk through outdoor education.

Risk level = how bad could it be x the chance of it happening

Danger

Rate the worst probable and possible consequence due to that hazard on a scale of 1-5:

- Cause for minor concern e.g. a small graze, helmet rash, a small bruise;
- Minor injuries treatable with a first aid kit but which wouldn't normally require the attention of a medical officer e.g. cuts, twists, scratch
- Injuries or ailments requiring evacuation and medical attention e.g. mild hypothermia, animal bites, an untreatable asthma attack, lacerations requiring stitches, minor breaks.
- Major trauma, epileptic seizure, head injury, major broken bones, significant burns, hypothermia, hyperthermia
- Death, paralysis, dismemberment, high voltage/high current electrocution, freezing.

X

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Likelyhood

Rate the chances of that hazard occurring on a scale of 1-5:

- Almost never – e.g. lightning striking close to your party
- Highly unlikely e.g. the chance of someone letting go of the rope whilst abseiling
- Happening every so often e.g. a serious change in weather
- Likely, if not probable e.g. a pebble falling off the top of an abseil pitch or a child tripping on rough ground
- Certain or almost certain to happen e.g. someone in your party getting tired on a long walk.

=

Outcome

6-8 is acceptable in outdoor activities (Although you may be able to reduce it with concise instruction and warnings).

Danger

8+? You must reduce it

If you identify a hazard and assess the risk to be greater than 8 you are expected to take steps to reduce the risk, which means clearly and concisely identifying the hazard to all people in your party, giving clear, concise instruction, issuing appropriate equipment and (*unless your purpose* is to lead your clients through the hazardous environment*) leading them away from the hazard towards an environment in which the risk is acceptable.

- *If you are contracted to lead clients up an ice climb (as an example), their purpose would be to tackle any hazards encountered including those rated above level 8 because the clients' enjoyment and fulfilment comes from that level of risk acceptance. However, even at this level the instructor should be taking reasonable precautions to ensure the safety of his/her clients - so a risk level 12 may be acceptable.*

Abstract

On occasion, an outdoor learning experience of great value may be judged to be right and proper even if some significant risks cannot be eliminated or significantly reduced. This is not a position to be entered in to lightly and without thought of the possible consequences.

5.2.2 Planning Tool

Risk Assessment Planning Tool

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toDo.!

5.3 Ensuring Quality

This document is in place to ensure that our client's experience is of high quality. It is based on 5 fundamental standards.

- Planning the experience
- Providing accurate information to guests
- Providing adventures which meet the needs of guests
- Reviewing client experiences
- Safety and Risk management

Prior to a client visiting we aim to capture their learning needs; we do this either through pre arrival communication via email or telephone conversation. Where this is not possible, we discuss learning outcomes as part of our welcome meeting with visiting staff. Once captured, this information is then shared with staff working with the group.

5.3.1 Providing accurate information to guests

It is of the utmost importance to us that we provide accurate, honest information to our guests in advance of travel. This includes, the quality and experience of staff, all costs being discussed and agreed in advance of travel and that all activities and accommodation are as agreed.

5.3.2 Providing adventures that meet the needs of guests

We make use of different locations and activities depending on the needs of guests. There are different sections of river that can be used, different crags and different excursion venues. Working with guests in advance of their trip and during, can make sure that we meet their needs.

5.3.3 Reviewing client experiences

Feedback is collected through daily conversations with visiting staff and group leaders. This feedback is reflected upon and working with the **Leadership Team**, changes can be made to the programme and staff coached to ensure learning outcomes are met. In addition to this we ask for feedback from group leaders once they have returned from their trip.

5.3.4 Safety and Risk Management

Safety and risk management is of fundamental importance to us. We have adopted the **Outdoor Education Activity Providors** national guidance for our approach to this area. Our approach can be summarised in the following sentence.

> We ensure the right leaders, do the right activities, with the right people, in the right places at the right time.

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6. Activities

6.1 Ardeche Descent

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6.2 Raft Build

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6.6 Initiatives

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6.7 Adventure Challenge

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7. Learning & Development

7.1 Learning Objectives

> **Info**
>
> You should define the knowledge and skill set of your target audience before starting. You can then use this information to avoid wasting time explaining information your audience already knows.

Just as stories are used to define software, learning objectives can be written using a standard template:

As a `user` *of the* `solution` *I* `know a specific piece of information`*, or* `can perform a specific task`*.*

7.1.1 For each learning objective, you should:

Identify what your audience should know and be able to do after they have read the documentation, and/or participated in the activity. Use that information to create a list of **Learning Objectives**.

Clearly worded learning objectives enable you to focus the content on comprehensive and coherent goals. Learning objectives should be evident in the title and content.

If there is no existing documentation set, some areas will be well documented, while others will either be poorly defined or missing. Expect to find duplicate and outdated content. Maintain a list of the best documentation you find for any learning objective.

7.2 Tuckmans - Stages of Team Development

Tuckman model is an approach to team development that helps teams understand their current state and develop strategies to move towards their goals. Tuckman (1965) identified four stages of team development, including Forming, Storming, Norming, and Performing, later extended to a Fifth stage - Adjourning.

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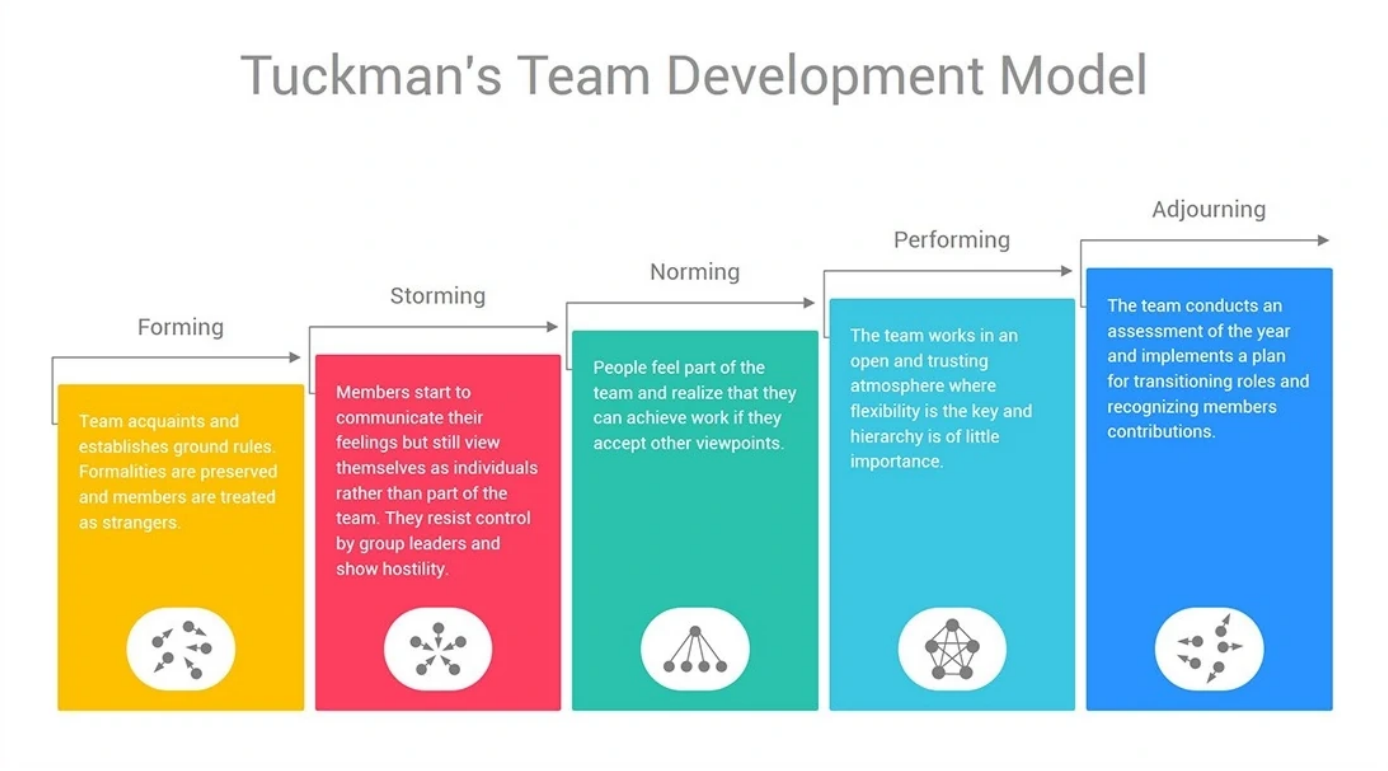

Tuckmans - Stages of Development

7.2.1 Five Stages of The Tuckman Model of Group Development

Forming

This phase occurs when new members join an existing team or organization. During this period, individuals are still learning about their roles on the team. They try to understand what they need to do to succeed. In most cases, it can take several months before people feel comfortable with one another. It may also take some time before you get your first performance review from someone who knows you well enough to give you feedback.

Storming

As the name suggests, this is the “storm” part of the process. Members begin to argue among themselves as they figure out where they stand within the team’s hierarchy. They might even start fighting amongst themselves. If left unchecked, this behavior could lead to severe problems down the road if not addressed immediately.

Norming

Once everyone feels more at ease, the team begins to work together toward common goals. People become familiar with others’ strengths and weaknesses and learn how best to use them. At this point, there should be fewer arguments between teammates because everyone understands their role on the team.

Performing

Finally, once all members have learned how to cooperate effectively, the team performs better than ever before. Everyone works together smoothly and efficiently towards achieving shared objectives. You know you’re ready to move into the next stage when you no longer hear anyone complain about working with other team members.

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Adjourning

Once the goal has been achieved, the team recognizes individual contributions and then disbands. This is sometimes called the mourning stage because members feel a sense of loss after separating from those they've shared a meaningful experience with. Any lessons learned from the process should be passed to a responsible person for use by future teams.

7.2.2 Which Factors Affect Team Performance?

The Tuckman model of group development considers three factors that affect team performance. These three factors are;

1. Content refers to what the team does, the actual work that they perform.

2. Process refers to how the team performs the work.

3. Feelings refer to how the team members relate to one another.

When a team focuses on the balance between all three, it can elevate performance.

The following table represents the team attitude on these three factors during each stage of development.

Stages	Content	Process	Feelings
Forming	The team attempts to define the work the team needs to do.	The team might seek external guidance to define how to do the work	Team members are unsure and may need a leader to guide them
Storming	Team members may resist the task demands	Member may attempt to avoid doing the work and find reasons to do so	Friction about individual positions & hierarchy of the team
Norming	The team starts to open up about the work and challenges	Processes start getting defined and adopted	Members become collaborative and start working collectively
Performing	The team meets work challenges and delivers	Processes ensure systematic allocation of resources and systematic workflow	Members share common objectives and become accountable
Adjouring	In the adjourning phase, the **Leadership** acknowledges the efforts of the team and, in the process, brings about closure.	Before this occurs, however, the team is assembled one final time and individuals are encouraged to share their experiences of working at the organisation.	It's important that the team does not gloss over any of the problems encountered or lessons learned. This is because the solutions and insights are valuable to subsequent teams who may find themselves in similar predicaments.

7.2.3 Summary

Abstract

The Tuckman model for team development is an excellent tool for helping teams understand their dynamics and how they interact with each other. It is one of the most widely used models for explaining group behavior. Understanding the Tuckman model helps us develop better teams and ensure effective value delivery.

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8. Resources

8.1 Resources

8.1.1 Risk Assessment

Risk Benefit Worksheet

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https://github.com/Matt-Adventure-Ardeche/staffhandbook

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